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Response to AI Action Plan RFI

I appreciate the administration’s commitment to strengthening American leadership in artificial intelligence and fostering a thriving domestic AI ecosystem. I write to recommend that the new administration should consider how it can support the development, adoption, and standardization of **methods for authenticated delegation to AI systems**.

“AI agents” are general-purpose AI systems that accomplish tasks by working independently for extended periods of time (minutes, hours, perhaps even days)—for instance, letting an agent [compile a detailed research report](#) based on proprietary info or [operate a desktop environment to automate routine tasks](#). There are many places across the economy, military, and civil society where this technology, once it exists, will potentially have a massive impact. If the rate of AI technological improvement continues as it has in recent years, the first versions of these kinds of general-purpose AI agents will likely be introduced to the world within the current administration, before the year 2028. However, as of January 2025, there is no widely-accepted technical or social infrastructure for delegating to AI agents in a secure, authenticated manner.

To address this, I would recommend an approach called “authenticated delegation”. Authenticated delegation is a framework that lets a user securely authorize an AI agent to act on their behalf by issuing a digitally signed token specifying precise permissions—leveraging protocols like OAuth/OpenID Connect to ensure every action is verifiable and auditable. This approach enables AI systems to act on behalf of individuals or organizations with carefully scoped permissions and verifiable identities, protecting both commercial interests and national security.

Below is a concise summary of the merits of this approach:

- **Innovation:** Authenticated delegation would promote innovation by creating common and interoperable standards for AI-centric businesses. This has synergies with the broader adoption of cryptocurrencies and other forms of decentralized finance, as machine-to-machine commerce will likely hook into the same infrastructure.
- **Security:** When AI agents can prove their delegated authority, personnel within our military, law enforcement, and in enterprises that touch critical industries can confidently automate sensitive tasks without fear of handing unlimited amounts of control over to third-party AI providers.

- **Incident Response:** Methods for authenticated delegation would provide delegation trails and audit logs that can help allocate liability if something goes wrong, aiding rapid investigations and reducing legal uncertainty, without requiring government licensing or prescriptive regulation.

A paper titled “[Authenticated Delegation and Authorized AI Agents](#)” has detailed technical specification for how authenticated delegation would work, so in this comment I will mostly refer the reader to that paper, and close this comment out with a few example actions that could be incorporated into the AI Action Plan to support the development, adoption, and standardization of authenticated delegation methods.

Public-Private Standards Initiatives:

- Direct OSTP and NIST to host a working group with AI firms, cybersecurity experts, and major platforms to draft industry-led guidelines on delegated AI agent credentials
- Encourage or fund open-source toolkits that integrate authenticated delegation into existing frameworks, lowering adoption barriers.

Federal Pilot Programs:

- Incentivize pilot deployments (e.g., secure government chatbots, delegated report-filing agents) that adhere to delegated-credentials best practices. This not only improves efficiency but also sets a baseline standard for the private sector.
- Incorporate these agent-security criteria in upcoming federal RFPs, thereby signaling market demand and accelerating private adoption.

Liability Clarification and Incentives:

- Work with agencies like the FTC or SEC to clarify regulatory guidance so that AI agents operating with authenticated delegation are recognized as legitimate intermediaries in financial or consumer transactions.

By championing authenticated delegation for AI agents, the administration can unlock the next wave of AI-driven services and capabilities. in a manner that respects property rights, bolsters security, and allows America to lead on this new technological horizon.

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